

ANI

STRIKING SYNERGY The BJP's Mysuru candidate flanked by party's Karnataka president B.Y. Vijayendra (left) and ally JD(S) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy at a rally, Apr. 3

Karnataka government had on March 23 filed a writ petition in the Supreme Court seeking the release of financial assistance—under the National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF)—which has been pending since October when an inter-ministerial central team completed its field-level assessment.

As Karnataka goes to the polls in two phases on April 26 and May 7, the clash between the Siddaramaiah government and the Modi regime is clearly emerging as one of the key themes. At his campaign rallies, Siddaramaiah's line of attack is the "step-motherly" treatment being meted out to Karnataka despite it being one of India's highest tax-paying states. But BJP state chief Vijayendra feels it won't help the Congress to hinge its campaign on a local issue. "People are smart enough," he says, "and understand that this election will decide the future of this country, not of Karnataka."

Of the Congress's twin planks in Karnataka, the guarantee schemes are the more potent one, feels political analyst Prof. Sandeep Shastri. "Saying that the Centre is discriminating against us at the state level...[will it] resonate with the voters is the question," he says. Besides, Karnataka's previous poll results show that the electorate always votes differently in the assembly and Lok Sabha elections. Shastri recalls how in 2014, 90 per cent of the respondents in a survey that he had worked on said they were happy with the Siddaramaiah government. Yet, the BJP went on to win a higher number of seats—17, against the Congress's tally of nine.

The Alliance at Play

In 2019, the Congress and Janata Dal (Secular) were running a coalition government in Karnataka with H.D. Kumaraswamy, son of JD(S) patriarch H.D. Deve Gowda, as chief minister.

BJP STATE CHIEF B.Y. VIJAYENDRA SAYS THE PARTY IS FOCUSING ON TWO THINGS—FIGHT THE POLLS TOGETHER WITH THE JD(S) AND WIN ALL 28 SEATS

However, the decision of the two parties to fight the Lok Sabha election together proved to be disastrous—both won only one seat apiece while the BJP went on to win 25, its best performance so far in Karnataka. This time, however, the JD(S) is part of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and will contest on three seats, the remaining 25 seats being left for the senior ally. But ensuring camaraderie between party workers on the ground may be somewhat difficult. According to Vijayendra, the BJP is focusing on two things—fight the polls together with the JD(S) and set a new record by "winning all 28 seats".

In pursuit of that objective, the BJP has replaced several of its sitting MPs. In fact, only 10 have been retained in their seats while new candidates have been brought in for the remaining 15. This includes the party's coastal strongholds of Dakshina Kannada and Uttara Kannada, besides Mysuru. It has also pressed three former chief ministers to contest the polls—Basavaraj Bommai and Jagadish Shettar of the BJP and Kumaraswamy of the JD(S). But when the candidate lists were finalised a month ago, there had been some pushback from disgruntled local leaders who had either been dropped or overlooked. "If they [the BJP] have to retain numbers," says Shastri, "they need a 100 per cent strike rate. It seems an uphill task at the present stage, because the party had not faced dissidence in the manner it has this time." A senior BJP functionary brushes aside these niggles, pointing out that the Modi factor will ultimately override the support for local candidates in this election. Instead, he points to the Congress list of nominees. "Where have they put up a serious candidate?" he asks.

The Congress does have its challenges: only six of its candidates have fought a Lok Sabha election before and as many as six others happen to be children of state ministers. Eshwar Khandre, Karnataka minister for forest, ecology and environment, defends the move, saying it's a good sign that the party has backed youngsters. "When we say it's a young India, youngsters should come into politics," says Khandre, who is confident that his son Sagar, 26, a law graduate who, incidentally, is also the youngest candidate in Karnataka, will pull off a victory in Bidar where the BJP has been struggling with dissidence. The Congress, says Khandre, will win 15-20 seats in the state. "Every day," he says, "the graph is rising." Vijayendra believes the BJP and JD(S) are safe in 22 constituencies but does admit there's a tough fight in the remaining six. "Day by day," he says, "things are improving for the BJP, not the Congress." And the BJP hopes that its Modi trump card will help sustain the Karnataka poll paradox, for now. ■